

Task 6 Report
Hyperboloid Cooling Tower Optimization

Group Project 2026

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Chapter 1

Objective

Minimize cooling-tower lateral shell area using SA, PSO, and BFGS while enforcing fixed target volume and scenario-specific constructability constraints.

The study compares stochastic and deterministic optimization behavior across eight structurally different problem setups while keeping common engineering requirements (capacity and realistic shape) explicit in the objective.

Chapter 2

Geometry Model

The tower is modeled as a stack of frustums.

- Frustum area: $A_i = \pi \cdot (r_{i-1} + r_i) \cdot \sqrt{(r_i - r_{i-1})^2 + h_i^2}$
- Frustum volume: $V_i = (\pi * h_i / 3) * (r_{i-1}^2 + r_{i-1} * r_i + r_i^2)$
- Tower totals: $A = \sum(A_i)$, $V = \sum(V_i)$

Lateral shell area is optimized (top and bottom caps excluded), which directly corresponds to shell-construction material for fixed end radii.

Analytic gradients were used for both **A** and **V**, and for all penalty terms, so BFGS receives exact first-order information.

2.1 Design Variables by Scenario Type

- **radii** mode: optimize interior radii $r_1 \dots r_{m-1}$ while ring heights are fixed from **z** levels.
- **heights** mode: optimize segment heights **h1**..**hm** while all ring radii are fixed.
- **joint** mode: optimize both interior radii and all heights simultaneously.

Chapter 3

Optimization Methods

3.1 Simulated Annealing (SA)

SA performs single-solution stochastic search. At each evaluation, a local perturbation is proposed and accepted if it improves objective, or probabilistically accepted otherwise using the temperature schedule.

This supports escape from local minima early in search and gradual exploitation as temperature cools.

3.2 Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO)

PSO evolves a population of particles with velocity updates using inertia, cognitive pull to personal best, and social pull to global best.

It is typically strong on global exploration and multimodal landscapes, but can require many evaluations to satisfy strict constraints.

3.3 BFGS (Deterministic Quasi-Newton)

BFGS updates an inverse-Hessian approximation and computes descent directions with line search, yielding rapid local convergence when gradients are informative.

It is efficient in evaluation count but can be sensitive to initialization and non-convex penalties.

Chapter 4

Penalized Objective and Geometrical Constraints

The optimized scalar objective is $J(x) = A(x) + P_{volume} + P_{height} + P_{shape} + P_{smooth} + P_{bounds} + P_{ratio}$ (terms enabled per scenario).

4.1 Constraint Terms and Their Function

- P_{volume} : enforces target cooling capacity by penalizing relative deviation from target volume.
- P_{height} : enforces total tower height in scenarios where heights vary, preserving comparable overall structure.
- P_{shape} : enforces hyperboloid-like monotonic contraction to neck and expansion above neck.
- P_{smooth} : penalizes second differences in radii to avoid oscillatory/sawtooth shell profiles.
- P_{bounds} : hinge penalty for design-variable bounds to keep variables in practical/constructable ranges.
- P_{ratio} (S8): limits adjacent-height ratios to promote constructability and avoid abrupt segment transitions.

4.2 Feasibility Rule

- Relative volume error must be $\leq 1 \times 10^{-3}$.
- If heights vary, relative total-height error must be $\leq 1 \times 10^{-3}$.
- If radii vary, monotonic hyperboloid violation must be $\leq 1 \times 10^{-6}$.

Chapter 5

Optimization Protocol

- Runs per algorithm per scenario: 10
- Seed offset: 0
- SA: $temp_{init} = 120$, $cooling_{rate} = 0.997$, scenario-dependent $step_{size}$
- PSO: $w = 0.65$, $c1 = 1.6$, $c2 = 1.7$, particles = 40 or 50 by dimension
- BFGS: $tol = 1 \times 10^{-7}$, $max_{iter} = 1200$
- Penalties: volume, height sum (when applicable), shape monotonicity, smoothness, bounds, ratio (S8)

Stochastic budgets are 10k evaluations for lower-dimensional setups and 16k for joint/high-dimensional setups. BFGS uses smaller budgets due to faster local convergence.

Chapter 6

Scenario Definitions

ID	Mode	m	Target Volume	r0	rm	Description
S1	radii	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Required case with bounded radii and required ring heights.
S2	radii	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Required case with wide radii range (unconstrained-like).
S3	radii	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Uniform-height radii design with bounded radii.
S4	radii	12	70320	39.3	27.4	Finer discretization (m=12) with bounded radii and smoothness.
S5	heights	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Fixed radii, optimize bounded heights.
S6	heights	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Fixed radii, optimize wide-range heights (unconstrained-like).
S7	joint	10	70320	39.3	27.4	Joint bounded optimization of radii and heights.
S8	joint	10	90000	39.3	27.4	Joint constructability-aware design with larger target volume.

Chapter 7

Cross-Algorithm Summary

Algorithm	Total Runs	Mean Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
SA	80	7814.56	5.277e-04	11500.0	0.5373	71.2%
PSO	80	8264.80	1.698e-02	11500.0	0.5744	50.0%
BFGS	80	7850.64	4.018e-04	4227.9	0.2097	72.5%

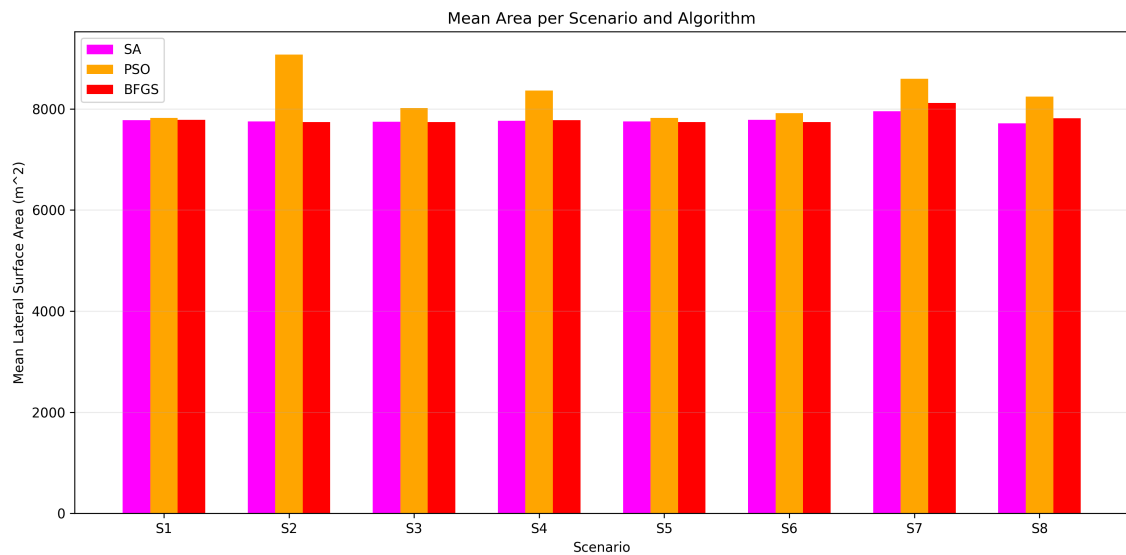


Figure 7.1: Cross-scenario area comparison

Chapter 8

Scenario Results

8.1 S1

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7782.01	0.00	1.537e-03	3302.6	0.1629	0.0%
PSO	7950.10	201.50	1.571e-02	10000.0	0.5322	20.0%
SA	7781.85	4.69	1.246e-03	10000.0	0.5033	50.0%

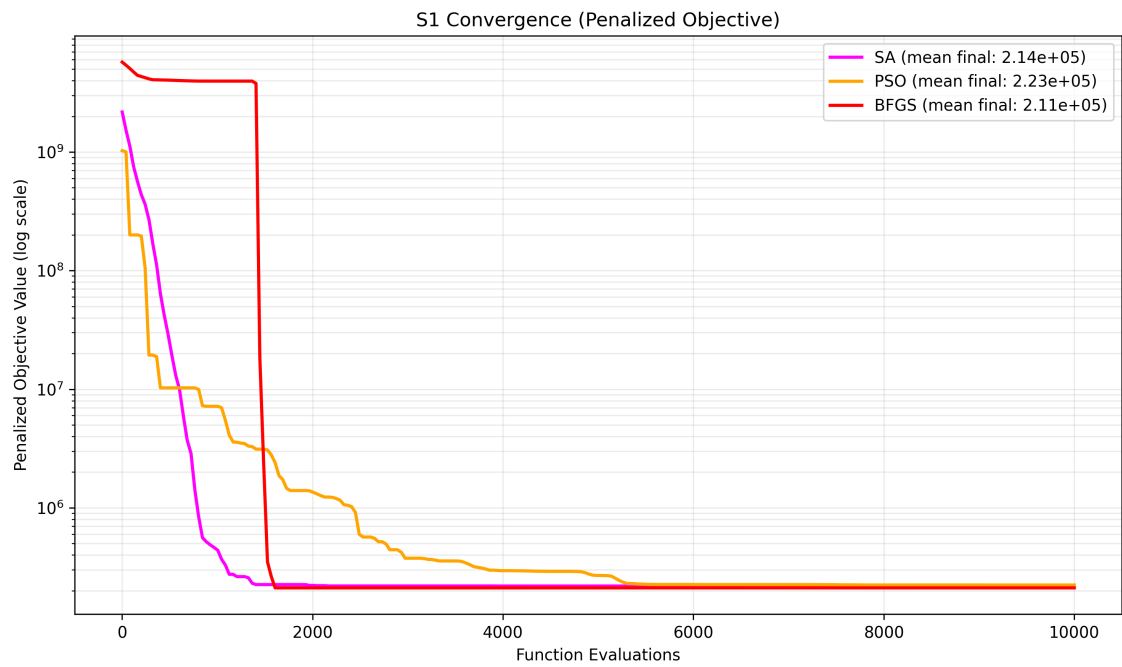


Figure 8.1: S1 convergence

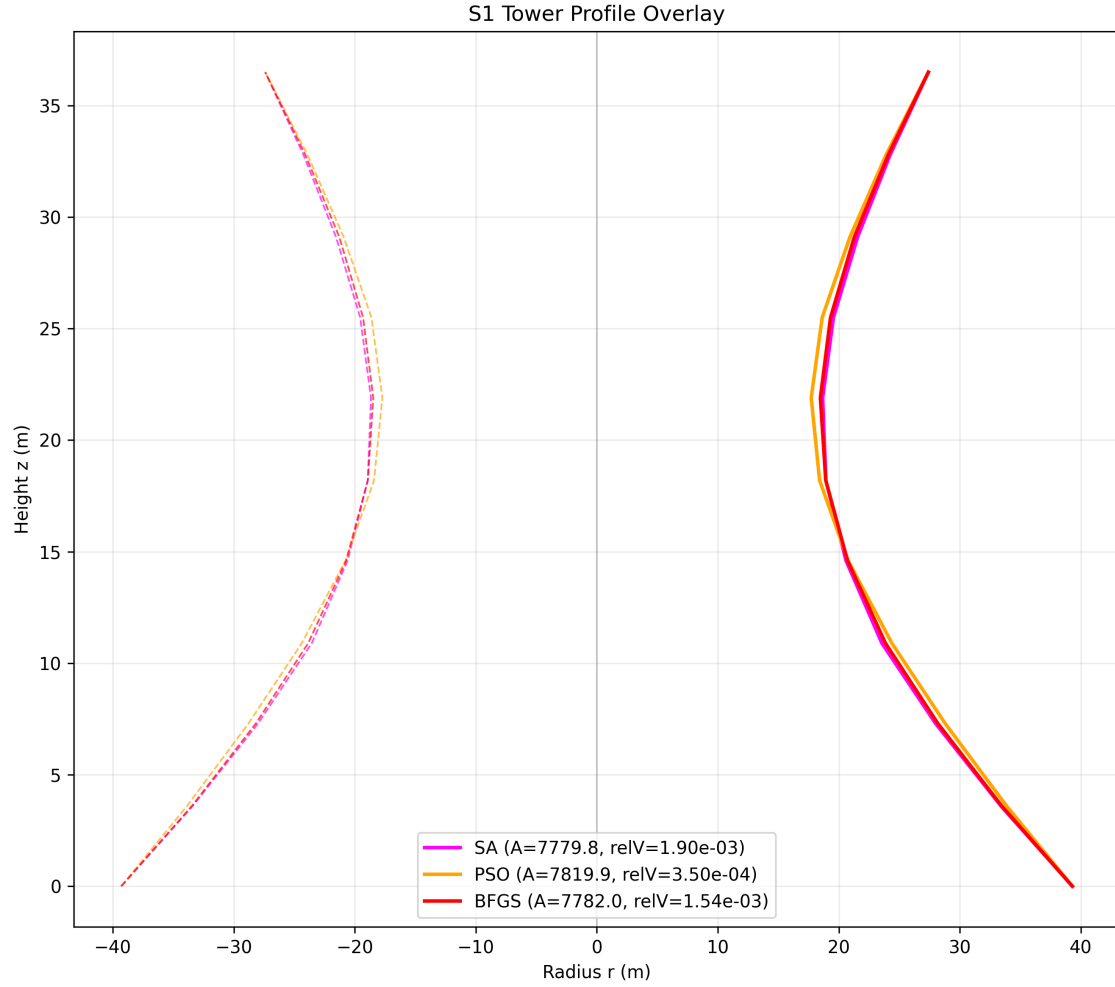


Figure 8.2: S1 profile

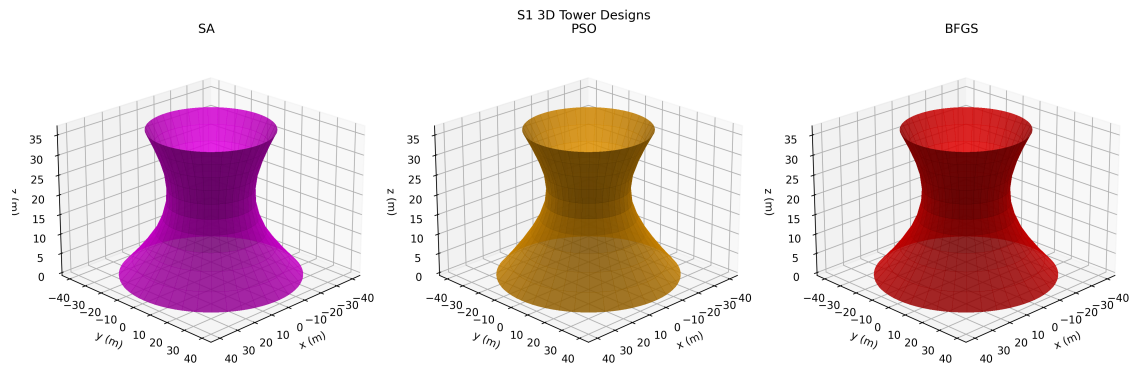


Figure 8.3: S1 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($3.037 \times 10^{-4} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$), shape ($0.000 \times 10^0 \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-6}$).
- PSO: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($2.407 \times 10^{-4} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$), shape ($0.000 \times 10^0 \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-6}$).

- BFGS: **INFEASIBLE** - fails volume ($1.537\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}03$). visualized run is lowest penalized objective among infeasible runs.

8.2 S2

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	8051.30	532.40	1.485e-04	3945.5	0.1556	100.0%
PSO	9352.84	524.78	6.536e-02	10000.0	0.4390	40.0%
SA	7753.26	9.27	5.492e-05	10000.0	0.4092	100.0%

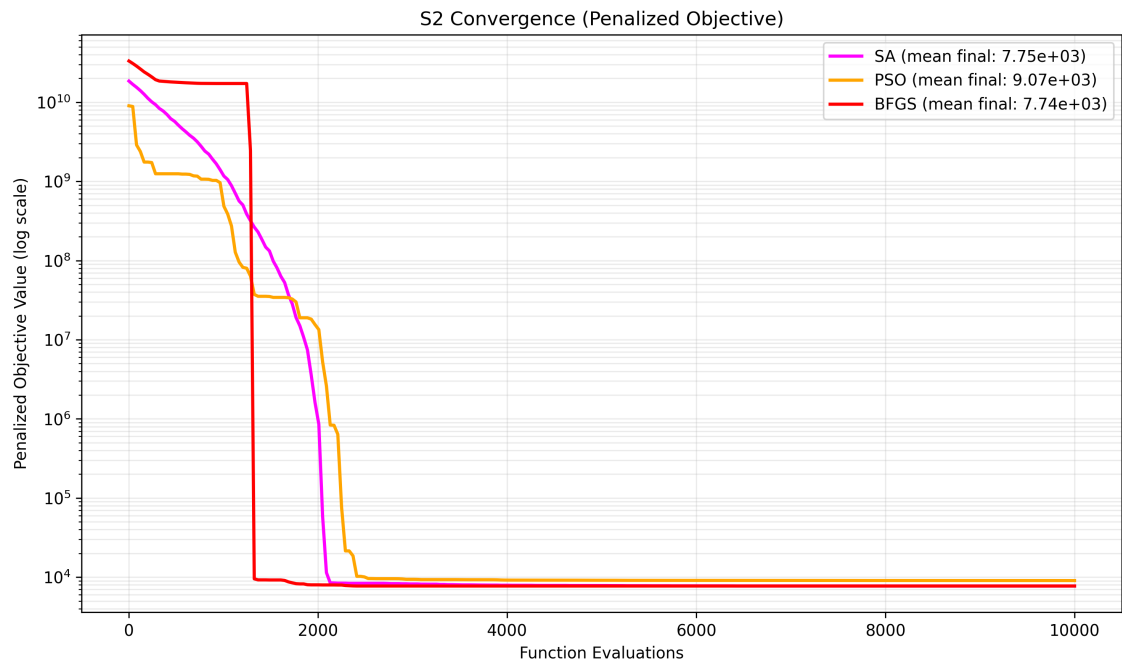


Figure 8.4: S2 convergence

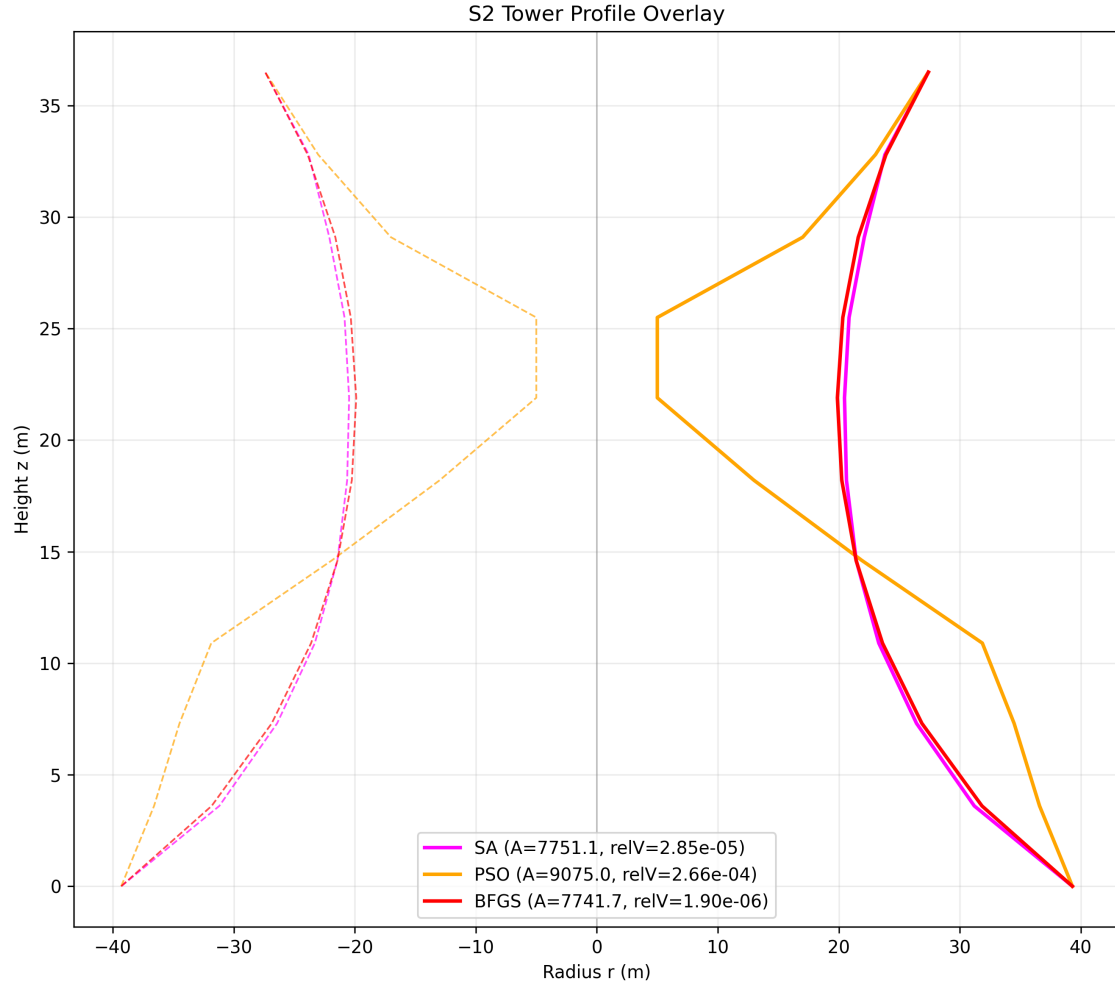


Figure 8.5: S2 profile

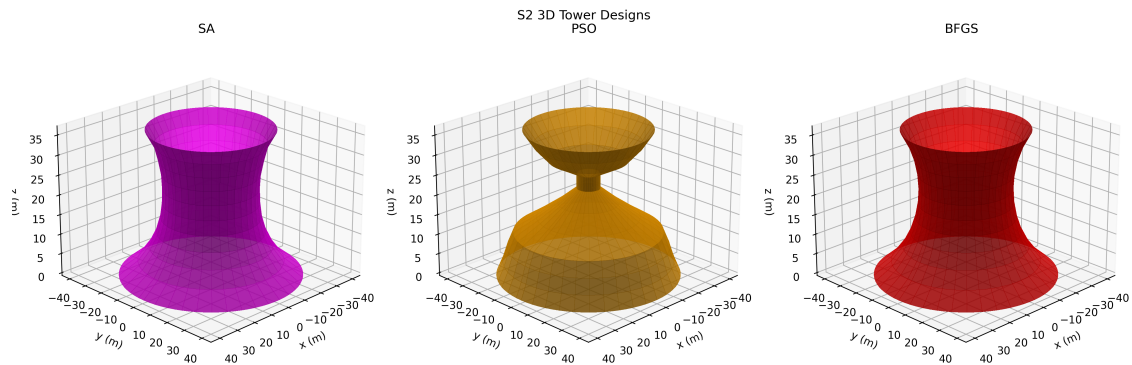


Figure 8.6: S2 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.686\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).
- PSO: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($2.663\text{e-}04 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.899\text{e-}06 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

S2 limitation note: although the selected PSO tower is mathematically feasible under the current rule, it can still look non-practical (abrupt throat/expansion). This happens because S2 intentionally uses a wide radii range and does not enforce smoothness or additional constructability checks; feasibility here only enforces volume and hyperboloid monotonicity.

8.3 S3

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7926.31	300.48	1.541e-04	2904.7	0.1227	100.0%
PSO	8258.12	351.80	2.509e-05	10000.0	0.4378	90.0%
SA	7753.02	21.36	3.424e-05	10000.0	0.4124	100.0%

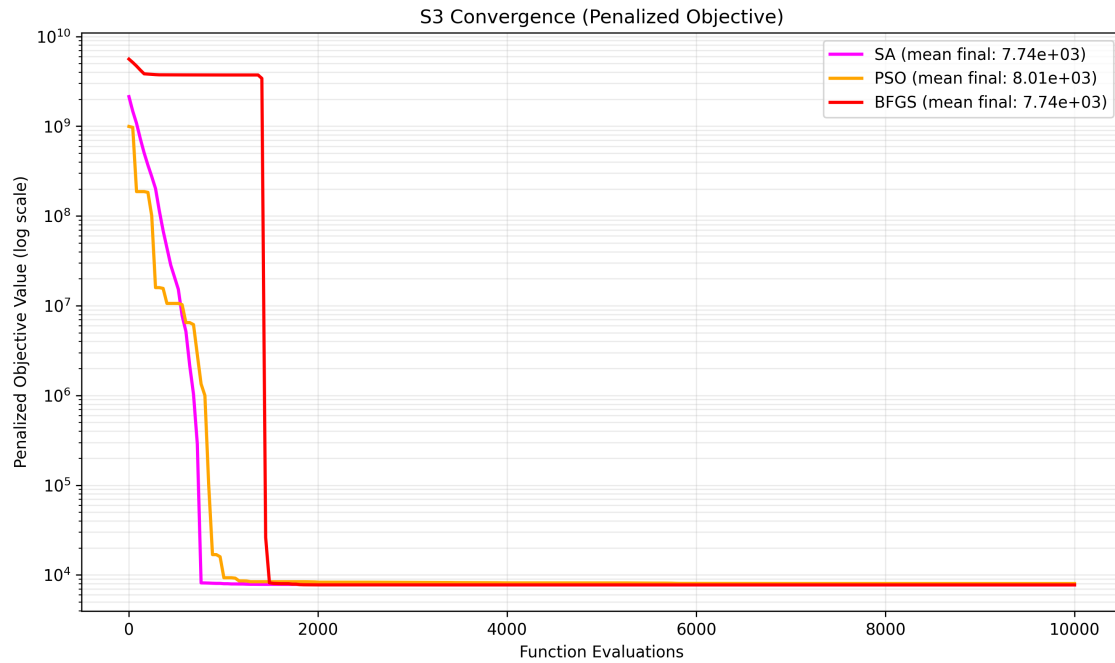


Figure 8.7: S3 convergence

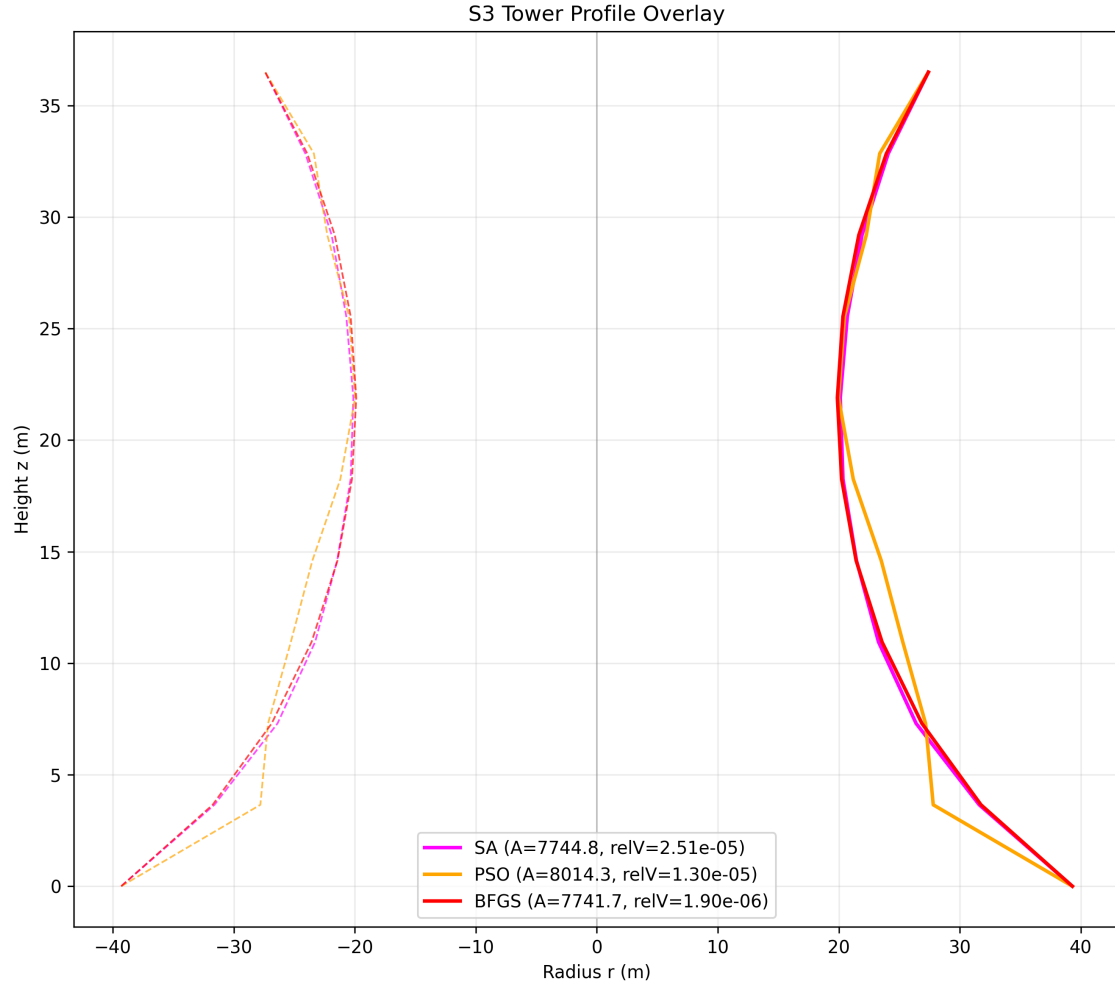


Figure 8.8: S3 profile

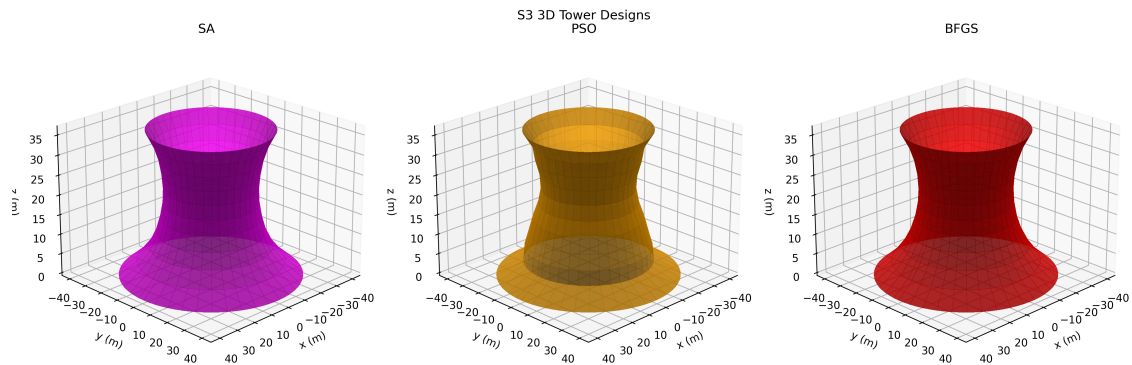


Figure 8.9: S3 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($5.257e-06 \leq 1.000e-03$), shape ($0.000e+00 \leq 1.000e-06$).
- PSO: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.211e-06 \leq 1.000e-03$), shape ($0.000e+00 \leq 1.000e-06$).

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.900\text{e-}06 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

8.4 S4

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7779.85	0.00	$8.915\text{e-}04$	4101.4	0.2508	100.0%
PSO	8269.55	447.60	$3.272\text{e-}02$	10000.0	0.5619	0.0%
SA	7783.18	14.88	$1.557\text{e-}03$	10000.0	0.5240	20.0%

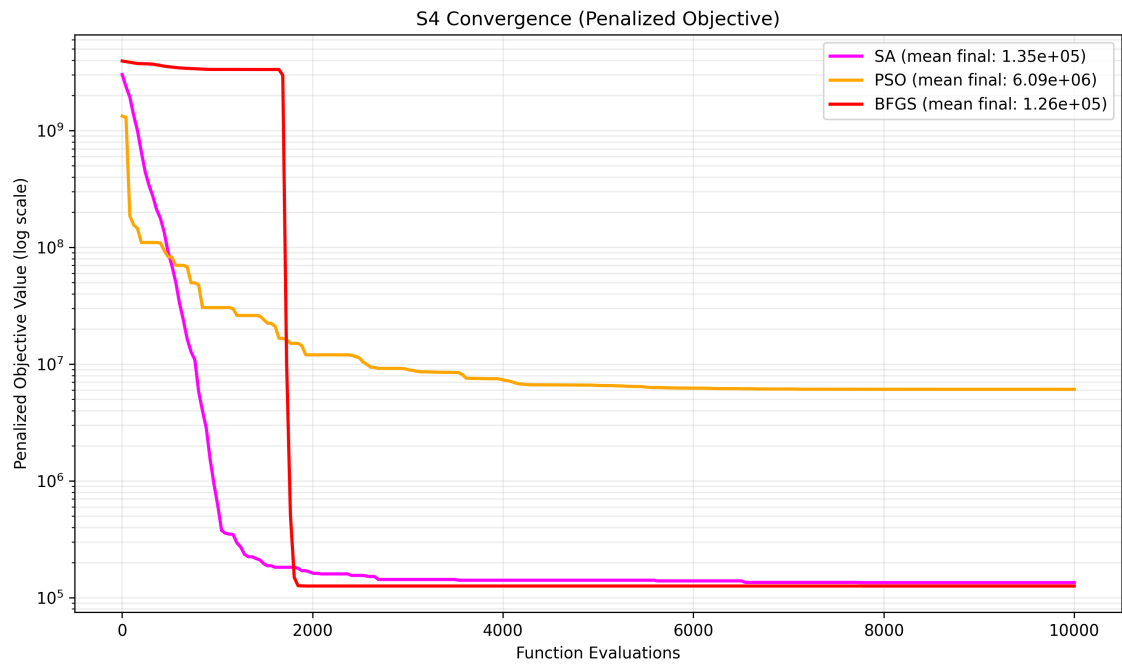


Figure 8.10: S4 convergence

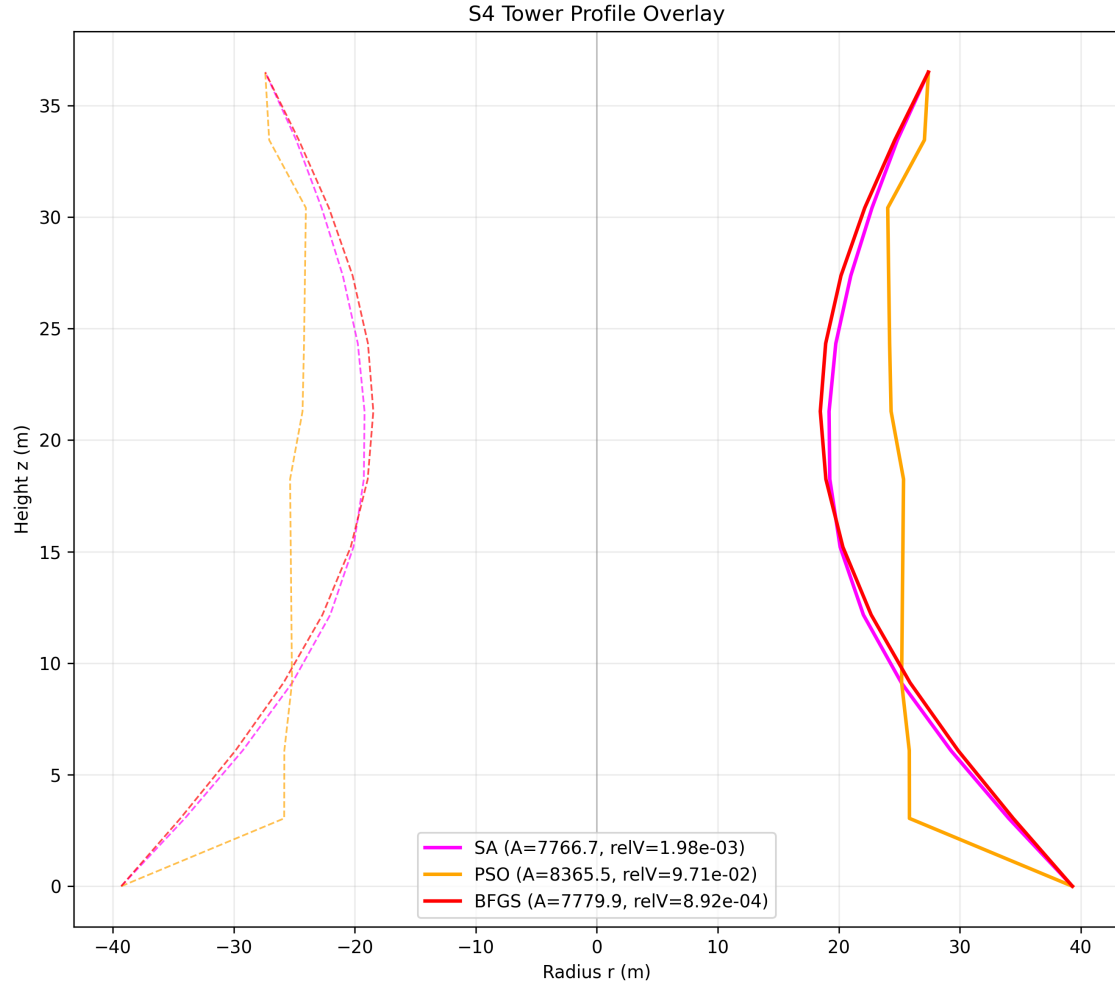


Figure 8.11: S4 profile

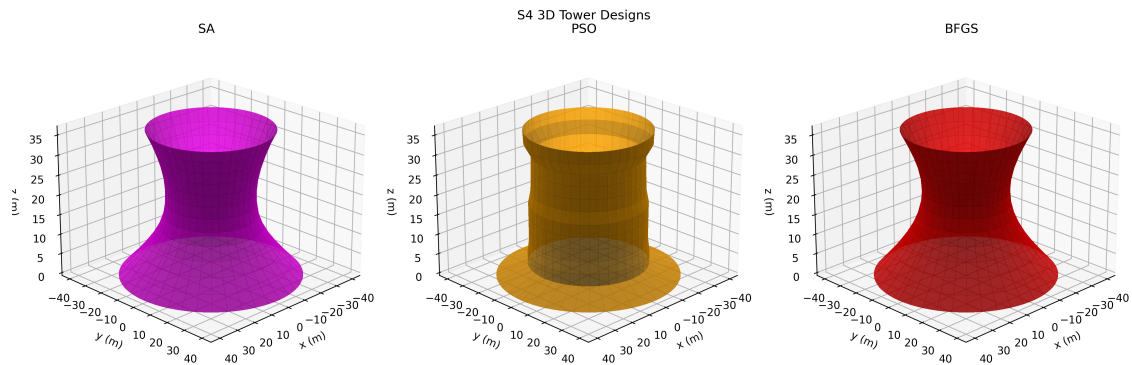


Figure 8.12: S4 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($3.986e-05 \leq 1.000e-03$), shape ($0.000e+00 \leq 1.000e-06$).
- PSO: **INFEASIBLE** - fails volume ($2.086e-03 > 1.000e-03$). visualized run is lowest penalized objective among infeasible runs.

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($8.915\text{e-}04 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

8.5 S5

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7742.56	0.00	2.331e-06	4164.2	0.1625	100.0%
PSO	7796.77	32.30	1.128e-04	10000.0	0.4147	90.0%
SA	7757.25	6.61	3.902e-05	10000.0	0.3880	100.0%

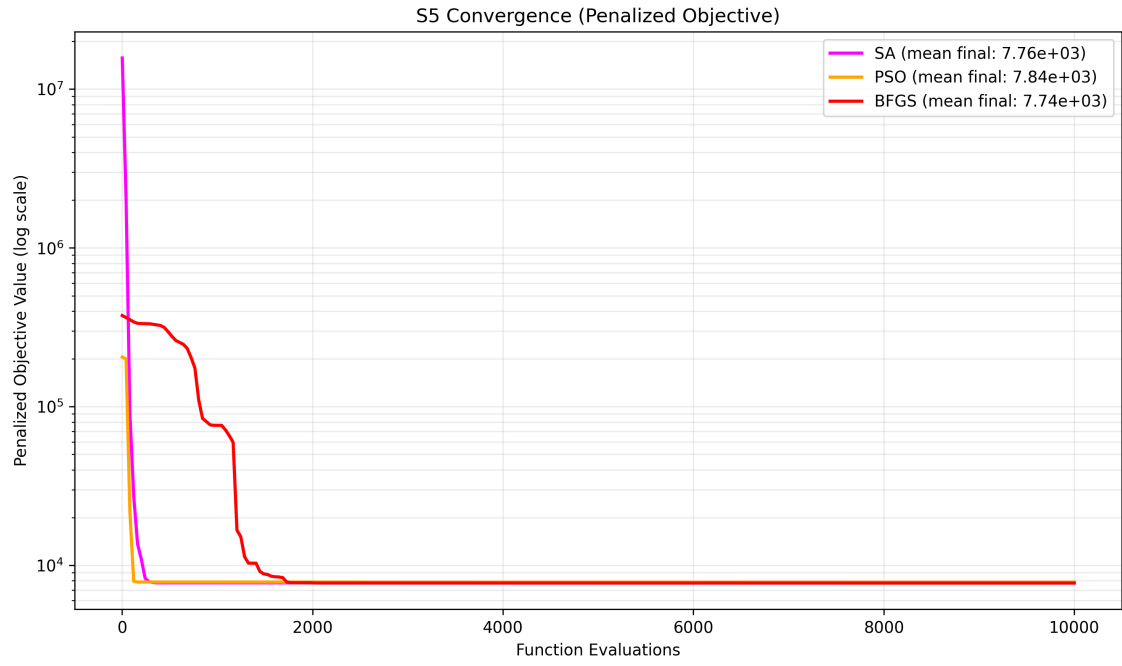


Figure 8.13: S5 convergence

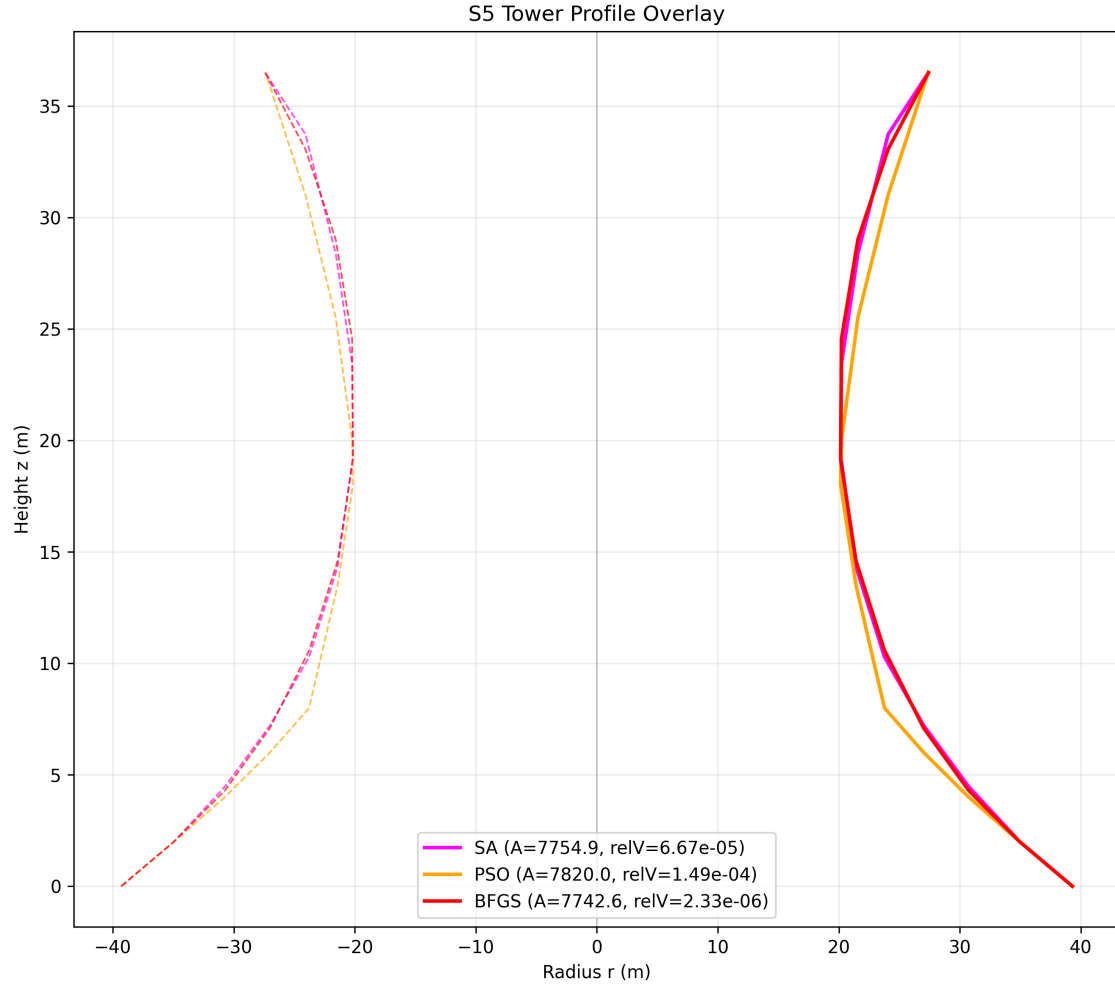


Figure 8.14: S5 profile

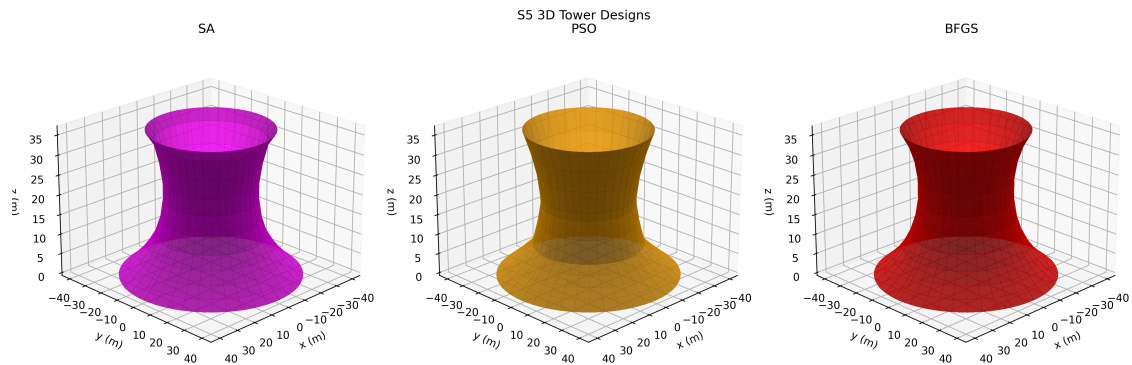


Figure 8.15: S5 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($7.754 \times 10^{-6} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$), height ($1.602 \times 10^{-4} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$).
- PSO: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($4.870 \times 10^{-7} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$), height ($6.591 \times 10^{-5} \leq 1.000 \times 10^{-3}$).

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($2.331\text{e-}06 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($8.747\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$).

8.6 S6

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7741.72	0.00	$2.071\text{e-}06$	1402.6	0.0551	100.0%
PSO	7913.68	146.68	$5.923\text{e-}04$	10000.0	0.4184	90.0%
SA	7825.77	33.17	$6.569\text{e-}05$	10000.0	0.3880	100.0%

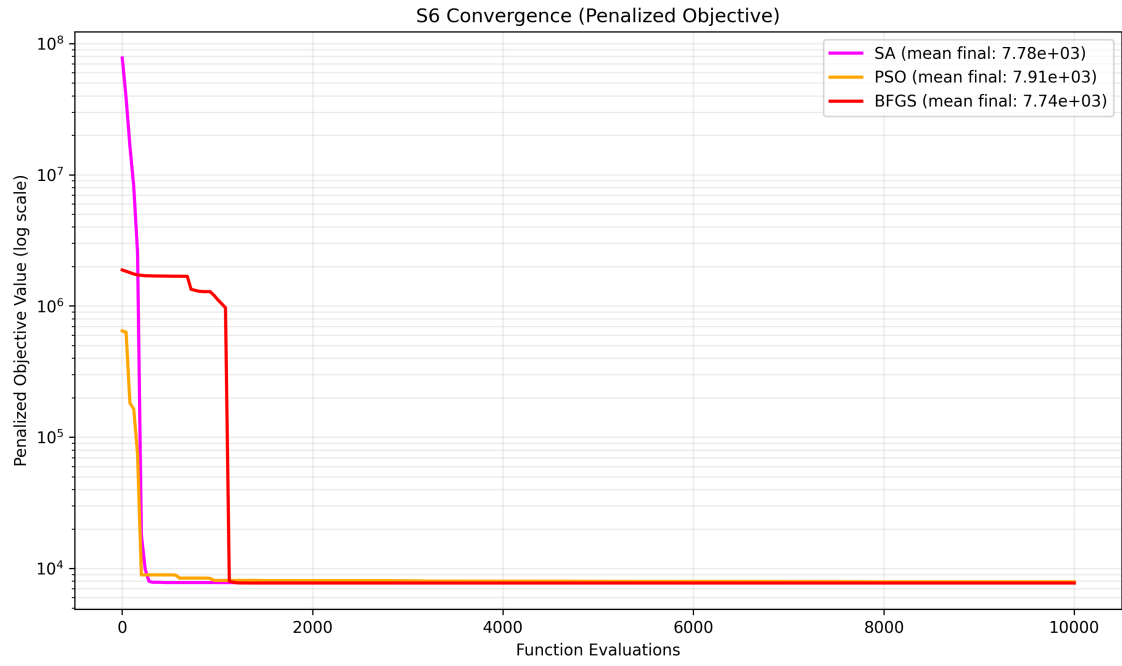


Figure 8.16: S6 convergence

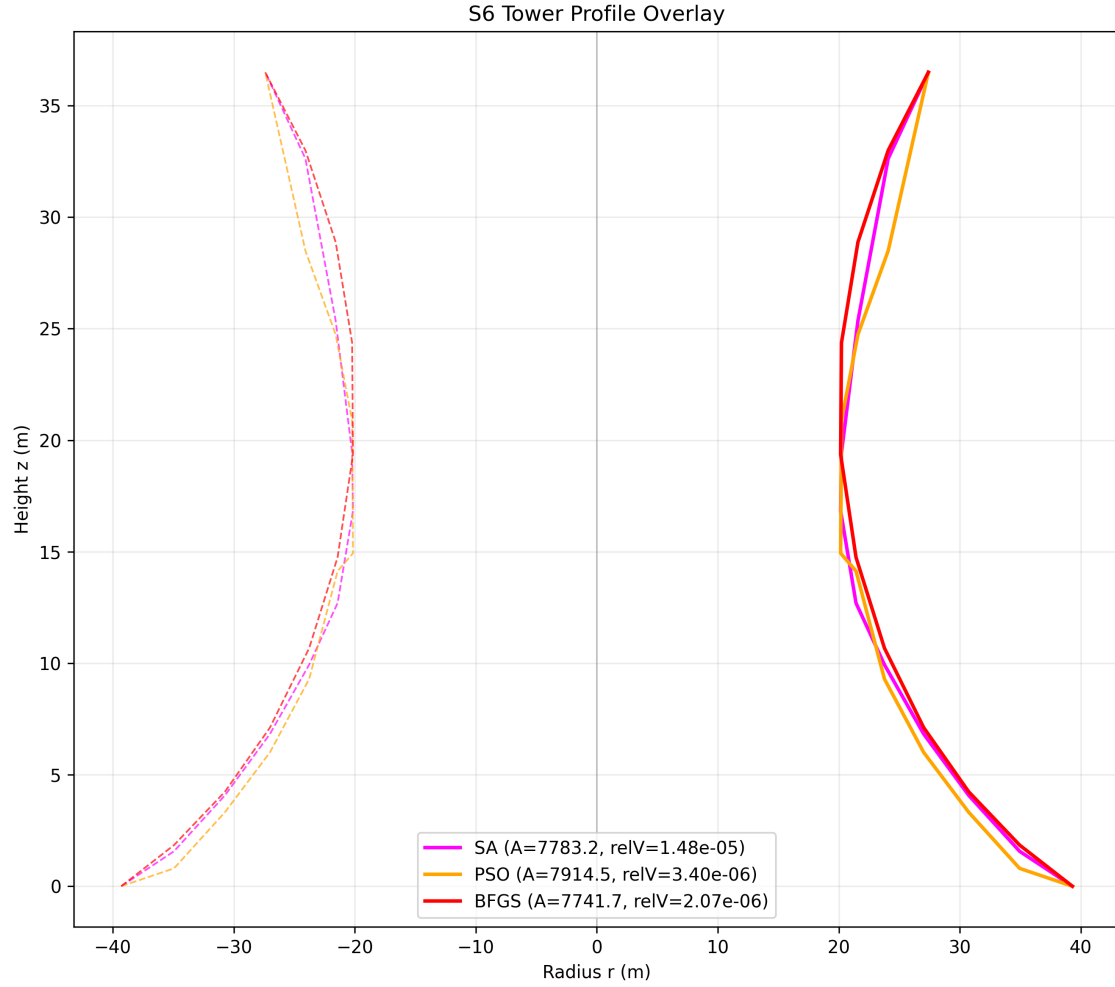


Figure 8.17: S6 profile

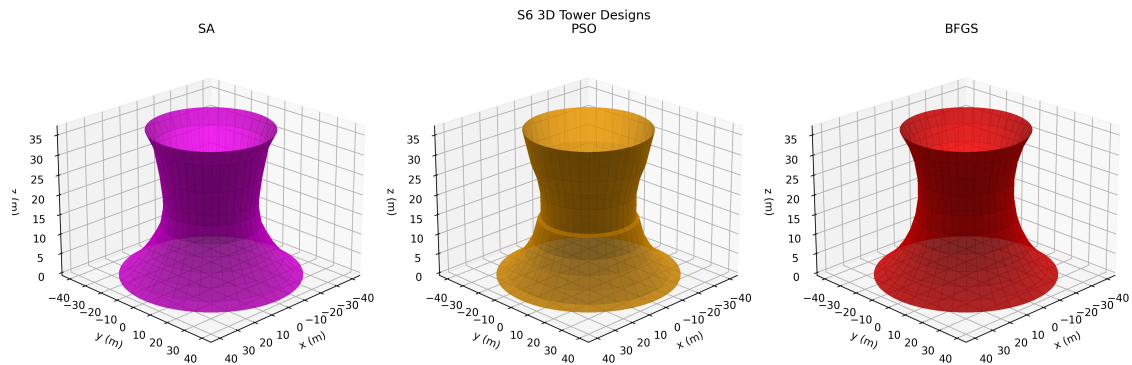


Figure 8.18: S6 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- SA: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.478\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($8.960\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$).
- PSO: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($2.557\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($5.838\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$).

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($2.071\text{e-}06 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($8.632\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$).

8.7 S7

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7968.31	369.60	6.476e-05	7000.9	0.3242	80.0%
PSO	8608.62	174.56	4.144e-04	16000.0	0.7688	70.0%
SA	8160.14	281.40	1.305e-04	16000.0	0.7203	100.0%

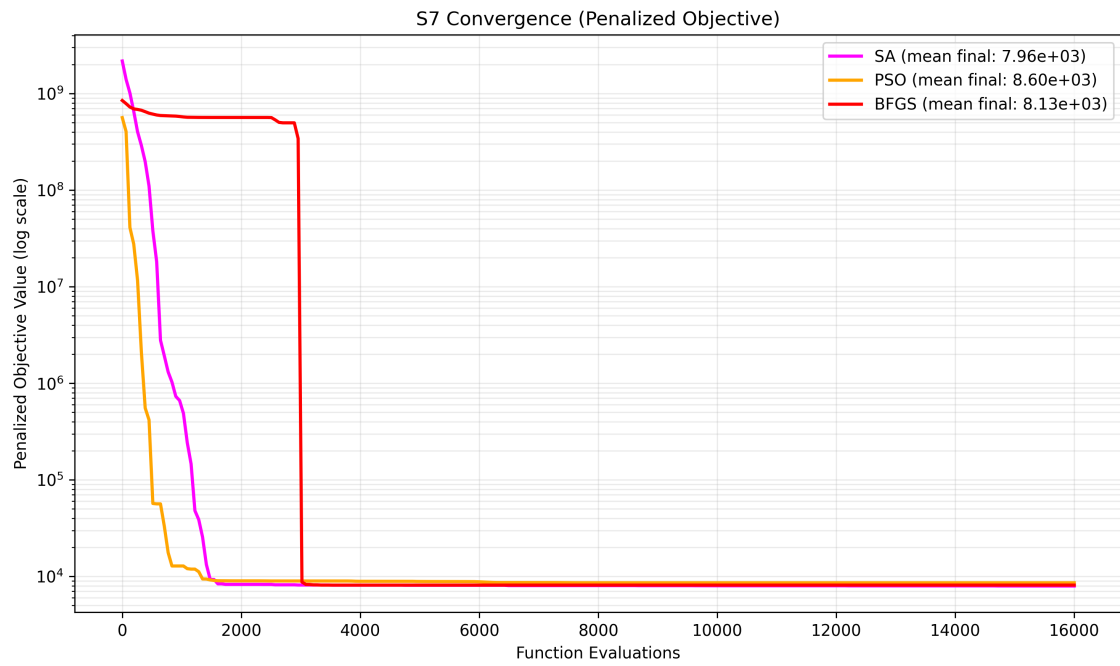


Figure 8.19: S7 convergence

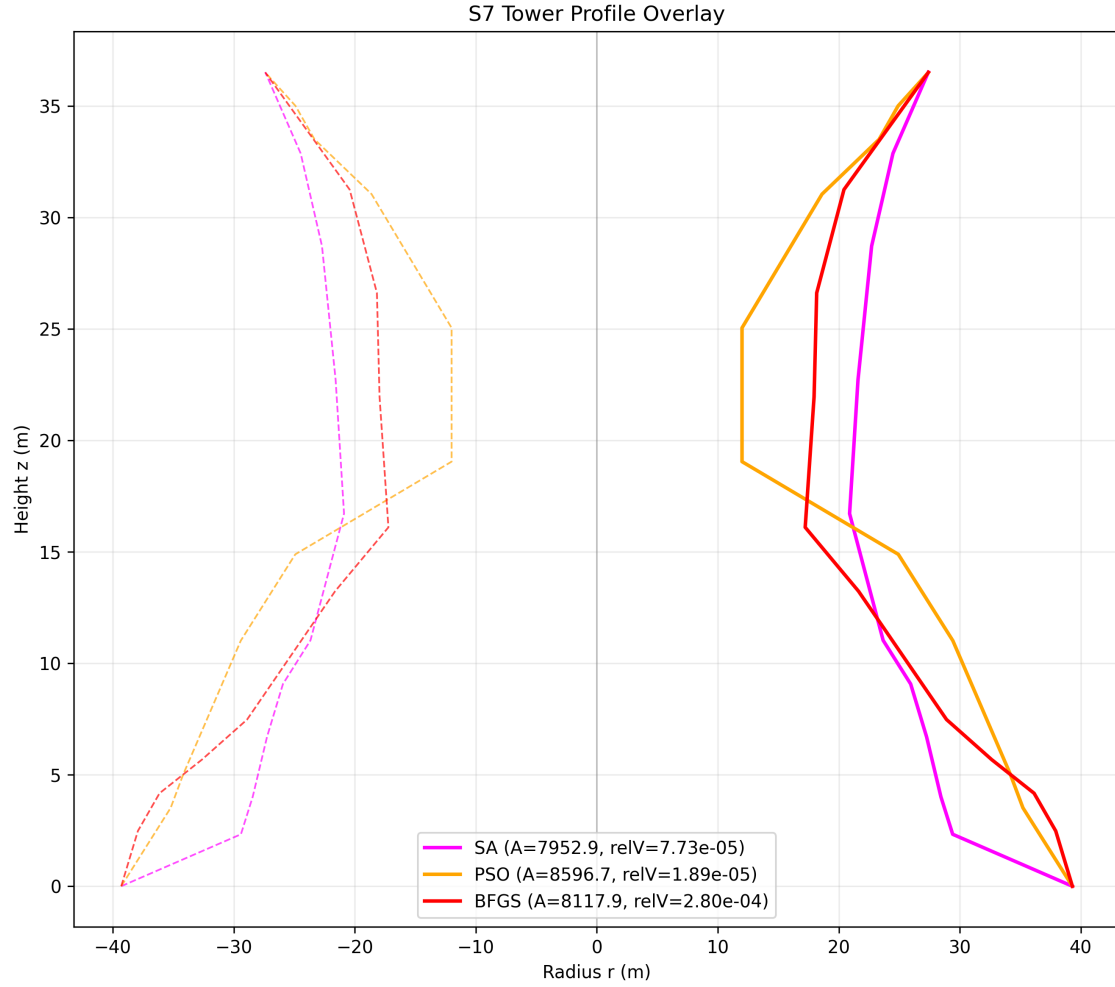


Figure 8.20: S7 profile

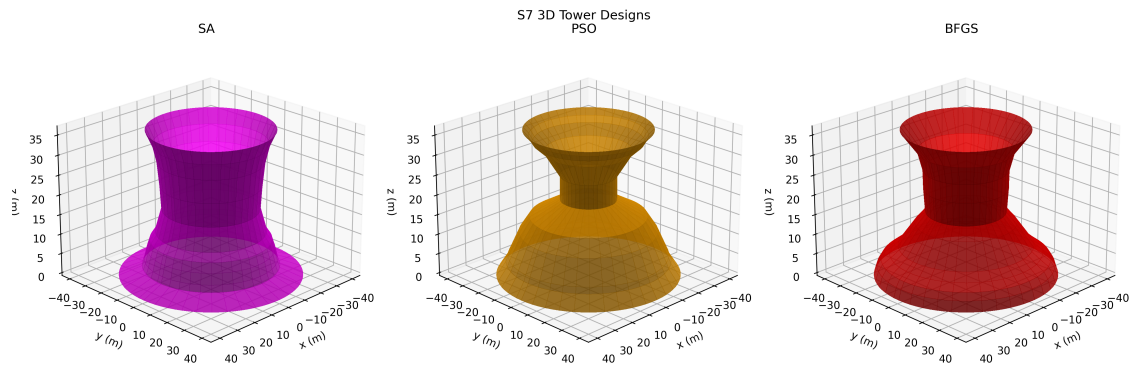


Figure 8.21: S7 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- **SA: FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.717\text{e-}04 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($4.769\text{e-}04 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).
- **PSO: FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($6.824\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($9.218\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

- BFGS: **FEASIBLE** - passes volume ($1.890\text{e-}06 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($8.481\text{e-}05 \leq 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($0.000\text{e+}00 \leq 1.000\text{e-}06$).

8.8 S8

Algorithm	Mean Area	Std Area	Mean Rel Vol Err	Mean Evals	Mean Time (s)	Feasibility Rate
BFGS	7813.08	0.46	4.146e-04	7001.0	0.4441	0.0%
PSO	7968.67	348.77	2.087e-02	16000.0	1.0223	0.0%
SA	7701.98	32.24	1.093e-03	16000.0	0.9536	0.0%

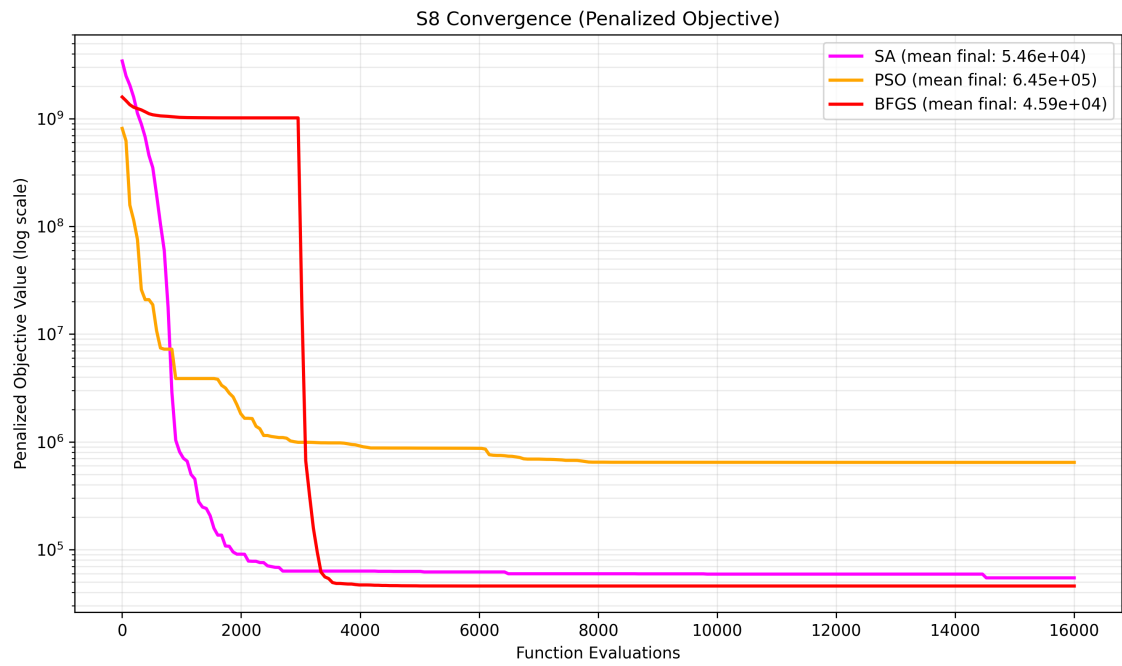


Figure 8.22: S8 convergence

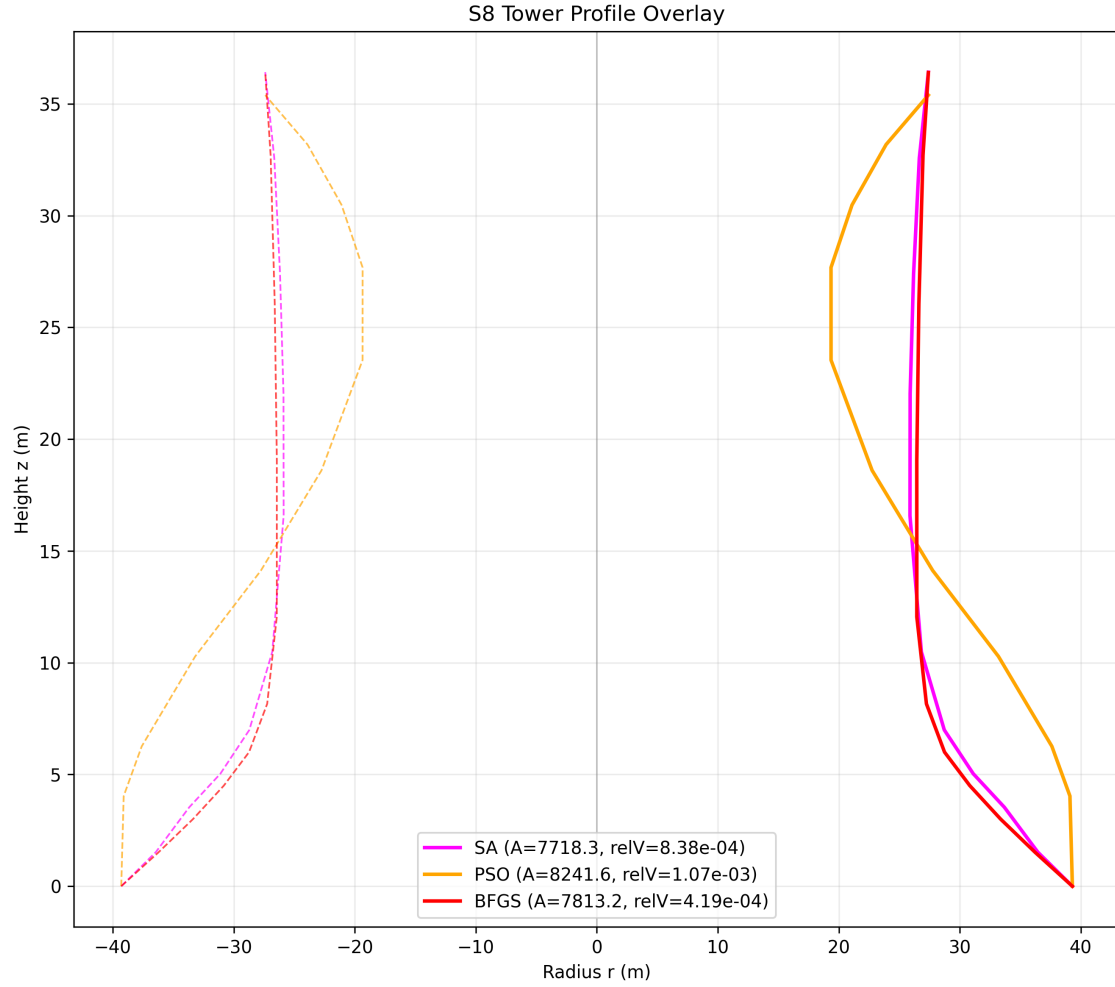


Figure 8.23: S8 profile

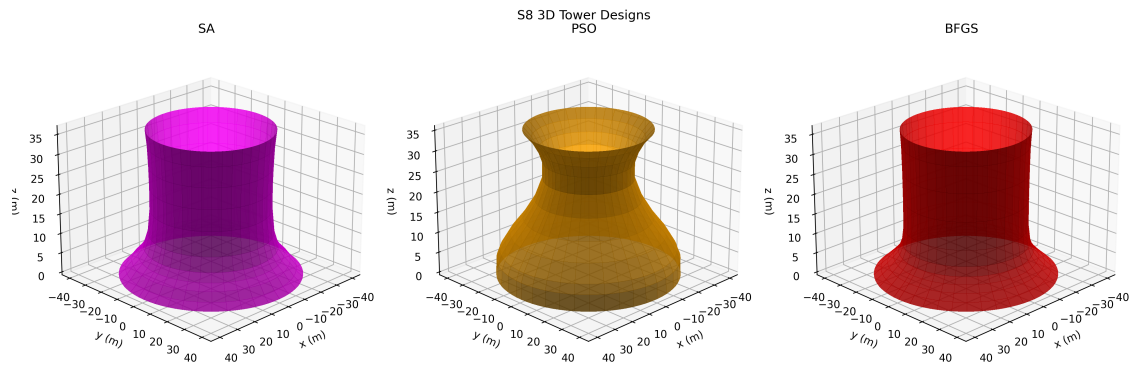


Figure 8.24: S8 3D towers

Feasibility of the shown 3D towers (same selected runs as profile overlay):

- **SA: INFEASIBLE** - fails height ($2.220\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}03$). visualized run is lowest penalized objective among infeasible runs.
- **PSO: INFEASIBLE** - fails volume ($1.192\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}03$), height ($1.597\text{e-}02 > 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($6.460\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}06$). visualized run is lowest penalized objective among infeasible runs.

- BFGS: **INFEASIBLE** - fails height ($2.684\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}03$), shape ($2.649\text{e-}03 > 1.000\text{e-}06$). visualized run is lowest penalized objective among infeasible runs.

Chapter 9

Key Findings

- S1: best feasibility-area tradeoff = SA (feasibility 50.0%, mean area 7781.85 m²).
- S1: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (3302.6 evals).
- S2: best feasibility-area tradeoff = SA (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 7753.26 m²).
- S2: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (3945.5 evals).
- S3: best feasibility-area tradeoff = SA (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 7753.02 m²).
- S3: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (2904.7 evals).
- S4: best feasibility-area tradeoff = BFGS (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 7779.85 m²).
- S4: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (4101.4 evals).
- S5: best feasibility-area tradeoff = BFGS (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 7742.56 m²).
- S5: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (4164.2 evals).
- S6: best feasibility-area tradeoff = BFGS (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 7741.72 m²).
- S6: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (1402.6 evals).
- S7: best feasibility-area tradeoff = SA (feasibility 100.0%, mean area 8160.14 m²).
- S7: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (7000.9 evals).
- S8: best feasibility-area tradeoff = SA (feasibility 0.0%, mean area 7701.98 m²).
- S8: lowest mean evaluation count = BFGS (7001.0 evals).
- Feasibility bottleneck scenarios: S8 (all tested methods yielded 0% feasible runs under current constraints).

Chapter 10

Discussion and Conclusions

Across all scenarios, **BFGS** achieved the highest overall feasibility (72.5%).

BFGS required the fewest evaluations on average (4227.9), confirming its efficiency for local convergence.

By raw mean area across all runs, **SA** produced the lowest average shell area (7814.56 m^2), but this must be interpreted jointly with feasibility rates.

Result patterns are consistent with expected method behavior: **BFGS** is computationally efficient and strong when gradients and local curvature align with feasible basins; **SA** is often robust under hard nonlinear penalties because probabilistic acceptance helps transition between constrained basins; **PSO** explores broadly but can underperform feasibility when penalty landscapes are steep and high-dimensional.

For practical engineering usage in this problem family, the recommended workflow is a hybrid strategy: use **SA/PSO** for global search and feasibility discovery, then warm-start **BFGS** for rapid refinement of the best feasible candidate.

The remaining limitation is that optimization does not by itself confirm structural suitability. **S2** shows that mathematically feasible shapes can still look impractical, while **S8** shows that higher-capacity, constructability-aware designs remain difficult under the current formulation.

10.1 Planned Structural Validation in Abaqus

The next step is to transfer the best candidate geometries into Abaqus shell models with realistic material properties and shell-thickness assumptions for reinforced-concrete cooling towers. These models will be checked under self-weight and representative environmental loading to evaluate displacement, stress distribution, and buckling sensitivity.

Multiple candidate towers will be compared, not only the minimum-area design, so selection can be based on structural feasibility as well as geometric efficiency. The Abaqus results will then be used to refine the optimization model by tightening feasibility rules or adding constraints linked to smoothness, curvature, and stability.